

BLACK BELL COMPANY

Lawful Evil



The Black Bell Company is a mercenary organization that specializes in public executions, political intimidation, and enforcing death sentences. Unlike assassins who operate in secrecy, the Company embraces visibility; executions are announced, soldiers march openly, and a great iron bell signifies the impending death, instilling a sense of inevitability. Once commissioned, resistance is futile, as their reputation hinges on the belief that no condemned person escapes. The Company takes contracts on various targets, including rebellious nobles and entire households, performs mass punishments, suppresses unrest, and oversees trials with predetermined verdicts, presenting executions as lawful conclusions rather than personal vengeance.



HISTORY

The Black Bell Company traces its origin to the final years of the War of Seven Regents, when competing claimants to the throne relied upon private armies, emergency courts, and public executions to maintain control over unstable territories.

Its founder, Provost-Marshal Odran Vale, had served as the chief executioner and military magistrate of Regent Malrec III. Vale believed that rebellion spread whenever punishment appeared uncertain. According to his surviving writings, private killings created martyrs, unexplained disappearances created rumours, and lenient sentences encouraged further defiance. Punishment, he argued, had to be witnessed, understood, and remembered.

Vale formed a travelling tribunal accompanied by soldiers, clerks, priests, heralds, torturers, and executioners. At its centre was a massive iron bell taken from a monastery that had sheltered rebels. Before each execution, the bell was rung once for the crime, once for the sentence, and once for the authority that had ordered it.

When Regent Malrec was overthrown, Vale refused to disband. He declared that rulers changed, but judgment remained necessary. He offered the tribunal's services to the victorious regent and presented himself not as a loyalist, but as an impartial servant of lawful authority.

The new ruler accepted.

Over the following decades, the tribunal became an independent mercenary company. It replaced its original royal insignia with a black bell upon a field of ash-grey and developed procedures allowing it to serve foreign courts, merchant councils, military governors, occupying armies, and religious authorities.

The Company's reputation was established during the Execution of the Twelve Towers, when twelve rebellious lords were put to death simultaneously in twelve different cities. Company detachments coordinated the ceremonies so precisely that each execution occurred on the same toll of the midday bells. The display ended the rebellion without a final battle and transformed the Black Bell Company into an institution feared across the region.

Since then, the Company has survived fallen dynasties, religious schisms, and the collapse of several kingdoms. It maintains extensive archives of contracts, verdicts, confessions, bloodlines, and unfinished sentences. Some of its oldest commissions remain technically active, awaiting the discovery of descendants or fugitives whose ancestors escaped judgment.

HOW TO USE THIS FACTION

The Black Bell Company works best as a recurring institution rather than a simple enemy faction. Its members should appear disciplined, lawful, and willing to cooperate with capable outsiders, even when their purpose is cruel or politically corrupt. The party may encounter the Company as investigators, escorts, witnesses, auxiliaries, or obstacles standing between a condemned prisoner and a public sentence. Their involvement should gradually expose the difference between lawful authority and genuine justice, forcing them to decide whether to uphold a valid warrant, expose a corrupted process, or manipulate the Company's own procedures from within. Successful cooperation can earn the characters temporary iron tokens, sealed passes, or formal recognition, granting them access to Company checkpoints, archives, prisoner transports, and restricted investigations without making them full members.

THE PRISONER WHO MUST NOT DIE

The characters arrive in a settlement preparing for the public execution of a notorious rebel commander. Ash-grey standards hang above the streets, soldiers barricade the market square, and the Black Bell Company has announced that the sentence will be carried out at noon in three days. The condemned prisoner secretly contacts the party, but does not ask them to rescue him. Instead, he claims that he is not the person named in the warrant. According to him, the true rebel commander escaped months ago using transformation magic and left a substitute in captivity. He offers the location of evidence that could prove the exchange, but warns that the Company will continue with the execution unless the party presents an authenticated countermand or undeniable proof.

Run the Company as firm but not immediately hostile. A senior warrant examiner may recognise the party's competence and formally authorise them to investigate, while the officer responsible for the prisoner makes it clear that custody will not be relaxed and the announced hour will not change. The investigation may involve locating the escaped commander, recovering magical records, questioning frightened witnesses, or determining whether the prisoner is telling the truth. The tension should come from the certainty of the approaching execution rather than constant combat. If the party returns with convincing evidence, the Company suspends the sentence according to procedure. If the evidence is incomplete, the characters must decide whether to obey the law, attempt an unauthorised rescue, or expose the truth before the gathered crowd.

GOAL

The Black Bell Company's declared purpose is to ensure that formally pronounced sentences are carried out without hesitation, concealment, or compromise, and its leaders argue that civilisation depends upon visible consequences, where laws unenforced become mere suggestions, rulers unable to punish defiance invite rebellion, and courts whose sentences are ignored become meaningless theatre, so the Company seeks to make its name synonymous with the certainty of punishment.

Its deeper institutional goal is to become indispensable to governments across the known world, ensuring that rulers rely upon it whenever an execution is too politically dangerous, logistically difficult, or symbolically significant for ordinary soldiers to handle; by monopolising ceremonial punishment, it gains influence over both rulers and populations alike, as its officers determine how sentences are presented, which accusations are proclaimed, what symbols accompany an execution, and what final image the public retains, meaning the Black Bell Company does not merely kill a ruler's enemies but actively shapes the meaning of their deaths.

Some senior members even believe it should evolve into a permanent transnational authority capable of enforcing sentences long after the issuing governments have fallen, treating a properly sealed death warrant as a debt that survives kings, kingdoms, and generations.

PUBLIC PERCEPTION

The Black Bell Company is viewed not as a typical mercenary group, but as a harbinger of fate, eliciting both respect and fear. While authorities appreciate its discipline and impartiality in administering vengeance as law, ordinary citizens react with dread, knowing the bell signifies impending doom for someone. The Company's ceremonies draw crowds motivated by both fear and intrigue. Its presence has caused rebellions to falter without conflict, leading communities to abandon or adjust their ringing of bells to avoid reminders of executions. Proponents argue it maintains order by ensuring that powerful criminals are held accountable, while critics label it a tool of tyranny, equating it to mercenary justice for sale. Symbols associated with the Company have gained morbid popularity in various cultural contexts, though unauthorized replicas are suppressed to protect its image. Rival mercenaries may mock its members, but they seldom challenge its contracts due to the Company's meticulous record-keeping and retaliation tactics.

SECRET

The Black Bell Company has secretly executed several innocent substitutes after losing the true condemned. Its senior officers conceal these failures by altering records, bribing witnesses, and declaring that the sentence matters more than the identity of the person beneath the hood. If exposed, the revelation would destroy the Company's reputation for certainty and prove that its sacred procedures are sometimes nothing more than carefully staged lies.

LOCATION

The Black Bell Company operates not from a hidden fortress, but from a permanent, fortified camp known as the Tribunal Grounds. Situated on a barren, windswept hilltop a half-day's march from any major city, the location is a deliberate statement of self-sufficiency and isolation. The grounds are encircled by a high, spiked palisade of blackened ironwood, and the only permanent structures are austere, windowless barracks of dark stone, a central administrative hall, and the towering scaffold that dominates the parade square. The location was chosen for its visibility and neutrality; it is a place that belongs to no single kingdom, existing as a constant, ominous fixture on the horizon, a reminder that the Company's authority transcends any local ruler.

Inside, the camp is a model of grim, law-bound efficiency. The administrative hall houses the Company's vast, labyrinthine archives—shelves overflowing with contracts, verdicts, confessions, bloodlines, and unfinished sentences, some centuries old, awaiting descendants or fugitives who escaped judgment. Adjacent chambers serve as planning rooms where advance parties map execution sites, identify escape routes, and demand supplies from targeted settlements. Soldiers in ash-grey surcoats drill in crowd control, prisoner transport, and ceremonial procedure across the parade square, while clerks study languages, law, and seal recognition. At the heart of the camp, the great iron bell sits on a wheeled carriage, always prepared for departure. Each evening, the Company gathers to hear unresolved warrants read aloud, ensuring no sentenced soul is ever forgotten.

This location reinforces their core belief: they are impartial, inevitable, and permanent. The camp is a constant, visible reminder that their services are always available, a place where sentences are not merely considered but prepared for—from authentication of seals to final rehearsal—with the quiet, unshakeable confidence of a hammer that has never missed its mark. It is the forge where terror is shaped into ritual, and where the dead are never truly allowed to rest.

CHALLENGES

The Black Bell Company's greatest challenge is its dependence upon the appearance of lawful legitimacy, because disputed successions, forged warrants, contradictory jurisdictions, corrupt witnesses, stolen seals, and fallen governments can transform a seemingly clear sentence into a political and legal crisis.

When the authority that issued a warrant is overthrown, the Company must choose between abandoning the execution and admitting that judgment is temporary or enforcing it against the wishes of a new regime and risking open war, while a single prominent case of mistaken identity or fraudulent commission could permanently damage its reputation for certainty.

Its ceremonies also create tactical weaknesses, as advance proclamations give fugitives, rebels, and rescuers time to organise, execution grounds are predictable targets for ambushes or riots, and the enormous bell and fortified prison wagons make its processions slow and conspicuous; resistance movements increasingly exploit these limitations through false witnesses, counterfeit countermand orders, substituted prisoners, magical disguises, hidden tunnels, coordinated crowd disturbances, and attacks timed to the moment of execution, while hostile rulers may refuse to recognise the Company's authority or accuse it of violating local law.

Internal disagreements present an equally serious danger, particularly between traditionalists who believe every authenticated warrant must be fulfilled regardless of age or political change and pragmatists who argue that the Company must adapt to preserve its influence,

and as its archives accumulate centuries of unfinished sentences, descendants of the condemned, obsolete dynasties, and forgotten claimants create an ever-growing burden of warrants whose enforcement may bring neither profit nor political advantage but which the Company's own doctrine makes difficult to abandon.

CODE OF CONDUCT

Members of the Black Bell Company must obey authenticated warrants, preserve the exact identity of every condemned person, and follow the established chain of custody from arrest to execution. No member may kill, torture, release, substitute, display, question, or alter the condition of a prisoner without proper authorization.

Charges must be read accurately, witnesses must be recorded, countermand orders must be examined, and every disturbance or irregularity must enter the official archive. Members may use only the force necessary to secure the procession and complete the sentence; personal cruelty, private revenge, bribery, theft from the condemned, unauthorized promises of mercy, and deliberate damage to Company records are forbidden.

A member who doubts a warrant must report the concern through procedure rather than abandon the assignment. Forging orders, concealing a pardon, allowing escape, performing an unauthorized execution, or using the Company's symbols for private intimidation is punished by formal trial before the Processional Court and may result in the offender being named upon the next warrant.

RUMORS

D6	RUMOR	TRUTH
1	The Company archives contain warrants so old that they now name the descendants of the original fugitives.	True
2	The Black Bell has never executed the wrong person or accepted a forged commission.	False
3	Some towns remove every public bell after witnessing a Black Bell execution.	True
4	Anyone whose full name is spoken before the great bell dies when it rings, even without a warrant.	False
5	Black Bell guards will protect a condemned prisoner from assassins, mobs, and even the employer until the appointed execution.	True
6	Provost-Marshal Severan Toll cannot die until every unresolved Company warrant has been completed.	False

REQUEST TABLE

D6	REQUEST
1	Transport a condemned warlord alive across rebel-held territory so the sentence can be performed publicly in the capital.
2	Investigate two conflicting but apparently authentic warrants before rival rulers turn the dispute into open war.
3	Discover whether a shapeshifter has replaced the condemned prisoner without delaying the announced execution.
4	Secure a city square for the execution of a beloved rebel leader while preventing both a rescue and a civilian massacre.
5	Recover a stolen Company bell and archive wagon before the thieves use them to issue forged sentences and countermand orders.
6	Capture the last heir of a fallen dynasty under an ancient active warrant, despite the protection of a powerful allied faction.

ACTIVITIES

The Black Bell Company undertakes missions involving formal punishment, political theatre, and state-sanctioned terror, most commonly carrying out highly visible public executions in which they secure the site, control crowds, verify the condemned, read official charges, and perform the sentence as ritual spectacle.

They also transport high-value prisoners in fortified black wagons, conduct punitive operations against rebellious settlements during wars and occupations, and stage overt manhunts marked by proclamations and tolling bells, while providing ceremonial security for trials, coronations, and forced political transitions.

Though they rarely accept covert assassination contracts, they will pursue targets for capture so that all deaths ultimately occur in public under the authority of the Black Bell.

ROUTINE

The Black Bell Company follows a rigid cycle of verification, proclamation, preparation, execution, and record, treating every contract as a formal legal ceremony rather than an ordinary military assignment; before acting, its clerks authenticate the issuer's authority, inspect seals and signatures, verify the charges and identity of the condemned, establish the required witnesses and method of death, and secure payment, after which an advance party surveys the settlement, selects the execution ground, identifies escape routes and potential sympathisers, and demands supplies and cooperation from local officials;

the main force then enters in a silent procession beneath ash-grey standards, accompanied by prison wagons, heralds, executioners, clerks, and the Company's iron bell, while the condemned is placed under constant guard to prevent escape, suicide, rescue, or unauthorised murder;

heralds announce the charges and appointed hour, soldiers secure the streets and surrounding buildings, and officers rehearse every stage of the spectacle until the warrant is read and the bell is rung three times—once for the crime, once for the sentence, and once for the authority that ordered it—after which the execution proceeds without interruption unless an authenticated countermand arrives;

when the sentence is complete, clerks document the death, witnesses, disturbances, final words, and treatment of the body, preserving the original report in the Company archives, while between contracts its members drill in crowd control, prisoner transport, execution-site defence, languages, law, genealogy, seal recognition, and ceremonial procedure, ending each day with the reading of unresolved warrants so that no unfinished sentence is forgotten.

ARTIFACT: BELL OF FINAL APPEAL

Wondrous Item, Artifact (Requires Attunement by a Creature Authorized by the Black Bell Company)

This black-iron handbell bears hundreds of crossed-out names. Its silver clapper resembles an executioner's blade.

The bell has 3 charges and regains all expended charges daily at dawn. Its tolls must be used in order against the same creature. The sequence ends after 1 hour, if the marked creature dies, or if a valid pardon is presented.

As a Magic action, you expend 1 charge, read an authenticated warrant aloud, name one creature within 60 feet, and ring the bell.

The target must succeed on a DC 18 Charisma saving throw or become marked for 1 hour. While marked and within 1 mile of the bell, the target can't teleport, travel to another plane, become Incorporeal, change shape, or magically disguise itself.

The bell always reveals the direction of the marked creature while it is within 1 mile.

As a Magic action, you expend 1 charge and ring the bell while the marked creature is within 120 feet.

Each hostile creature of your choice within 60 feet must make a DC 18 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 27 (6d8) Thunder damage and can't speak or cast spells with Verbal components until the end of your next turn. On a successful save, it takes half as much damage only.

The marked creature has Disadvantage on this saving throw.



PROVOST-MARSHAL SEVERAN TOLL

Lawful Evil, Male, Human, 63, First Voice of the Black Bell Company

Severan Toll was born in a provincial prison-fortress, the son of a military clerk and a state executioner. From childhood he was surrounded by warrants, confessions, condemned prisoners, and officials who spoke of death as an administrative necessity. His father taught him how to carry out a sentence without anger, while his mother taught him that a poorly written order could be more dangerous than any weapon.

Severan entered military service as a tribunal clerk and quickly gained a reputation for extraordinary patience and precision. During a border rebellion, he discovered that several prisoners had been executed under contradictory orders. Rather than conceal the mistake, Severan publicly exposed the responsible officers and personally supervised their executions under the same laws they had abused.

The incident brought him to the attention of the Black Bell Company. He joined as a warrant examiner and rose through its ranks by resolving disputed commissions, exposing forged seals, and completing sentences that other officers considered politically impossible. His most famous achievement was the Judgment of Hollow Crown, in which he entered a city controlled by three rival claimants, proved that each had signed the same condemned general's warrant, and compelled all three factions to witness the execution without breaking their temporary truce.

Severan eventually became Provost-Marshal after his predecessor disappeared while investigating a false royal commission. Upon taking command, he reorganised the Company's archives, strengthened its procedures, and declared that no execution should depend solely upon the wishes of a living ruler. To Severan, a properly authenticated sentence is not a request but a permanent obligation.

Today he leads the Black Bell Company from a mobile tribunal known as the Processional Court. He rarely performs executions personally, yet he attends every politically significant sentence and reads the final warrant in a voice said to remain unchanged even under arrows, riots, or magical attack. Severan does not enjoy suffering, spectacle, or bloodshed. What he values is the moment when resistance ends and the condemned understands that no argument, payment, or title can alter the procedure already set in motion.



PROVOST-MARSHAL SEVERAN TOLL

Medium Humanoid (Human), Lawful Evil

AC 18

Initiative +2 (12)

HP 170 (20d8 + 80)

Speed 30 ft.

		Mod	Save			Mod	Save
STR	14	+2	+6	INT	18	+4	+8
DEX	14	+2	+6	WIS	18	+4	+8
CON	18	+4	+8	CHA	20	+5	+9

Skills History +8, Insight +12, Investigation +12, Intimidation +9, Perception +8, Persuasion +9

Condition Immunities Frightened

Senses passive Perception 18

Languages Common plus 4 others

CR 10 (XP 5,900; PB +4)

TRAITS

Authority of the Warrant. Severan has Advantage on Charisma checks made against soldiers, officials, judges, prisoners, and creatures acting under formal orders. He also has Advantage on Intelligence checks made to identify forged documents, seals, signatures, or legal irregularities.

Unshaken Procedure. Severan cannot be Frightened, and magic cannot compel him to speak a deliberate falsehood. He has Advantage on saving throws against being Charmed.

Sentence Already Passed. At the start of combat, Severan designates one creature he can see within 60 feet as the Condemned. Severan and allied creatures have Advantage on

opportunity attacks against the Condemned. The Condemned cannot benefit from the Disengage action while within 30 feet of Severan.

Commanding Presence. Allied Black Bell creatures within 30 feet of Severan have Advantage on saving throws against being Charmed or Frightened.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Severan makes three attacks with the Marshal's Cane or Warrant Pistol.

Marshal's Cane. *Melee Attack Roll:* +8, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage plus 9 (2d8) psychic damage. If the target is the Condemned, its Speed is reduced by 10 feet until the start of Severan's next turn.

Warrant Pistol. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +8, range 40/120 ft. *Hit:* 13 (2d8 + 4) piercing damage.

Read the Sentence (Recharge 5–6). Severan presents an authenticated warrant and declares judgment against one creature he can see within 60 feet. The target must make a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw. On a failed save, it takes 27 (6d8) psychic damage and is Frightened of Severan for 1 minute. While Frightened in this way, the target's Speed is reduced to 0 whenever it can hear a bell. The target repeats the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on a success.

Third Toll (1/Day). Severan strikes his staff against the ground, producing the sound of a tremendous bell audible out to 300 feet. Each hostile creature of his choice within 60 feet must make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw, taking 36 (8d8) thunder damage and falling Prone on a failed save, or taking half as much damage on a successful one. The Condemned has Disadvantage on this saving throw.

BEHAVIOR

- Never raises his voice, even during violence or open defiance.
- Believes mercy without legal authority is a form of corruption.
- Refuses bribes but accepts formal payments, concessions, and amended contracts.
- Shows greater anger toward forged documents than toward attempted murder.
- Memorises the names of everyone who obstructs a Company sentence.

HOW HE TALKS

Severan speaks with formal precision, using complete titles, exact dates, and carefully defined terms. He avoids insults and emotional accusations, preferring to describe consequences as inevitable stages of an established process. His calmness makes even ordinary statements sound like verdicts.

Example Quote:

"You mistake my patience for uncertainty. The sentence was decided before I entered this room. I am here only to ensure that it becomes visible."

VESPER ROOK

Lawful Neutral, Female, Half-Elf, 46, Master of the Final Procession

Vesper Rook was born among a travelling community of actors, musicians, animal handlers, and stagehands. Her family taught her how to command an audience's attention, control the rhythm of a performance, and transform a bare town square into a place where every eye turned toward the same point. She might have inherited their theatre had a provincial governor not accused the troupe of spreading coded messages for local rebels.

The trial lasted less than an hour. Vesper's parents and six other performers were publicly executed before a disorderly crowd, but the ceremony was so poorly managed that the prisoners could not hear the charges, the audience began fighting, and one executioner killed the wrong condemned man. Vesper survived only because she had been sent ahead to prepare the troupe's next performance.

She did not respond by rejecting public punishment. Instead, she became obsessed with the belief that her family's deaths had been made meaningless through incompetence.

Vesper joined the Black Bell Company as a procession marshal, bringing with her an unmatched understanding of staging, timing, acoustics, crowd movement, and spectacle. She redesigned its public ceremonies so that every witness could hear the warrant, every soldier knew their position, and every interruption could be contained without breaking the ritual.

Her reputation was secured during the Red Amphitheatre Riot. When thousands of spectators attempted to free a popular rebel captain, Vesper redirected the crowd through carefully opened barricades, isolated the rescuers, and completed the execution without ordering a general massacre.

Today Vesper plans the Company's most important executions. She selects the route, platform, witnesses, symbols, final gestures, and exact moment when the bell is rung. Although she possesses no legal authority to pronounce a sentence, even Severan Toll rarely proceeds without her assurance that the public is ready to understand it.

Vesper believes that death alone accomplishes little. What matters is the story that remains after the body is removed.



VESPER ROOK

Medium Humanoid (Half-Elf), Lawful Neutral

AC 17

Initiative +5 (15)

HP 144 (17d8 + 68)

Speed 30 ft.

		Mod	Save			Mod	Save
STR	11	+0	+4	INT	18	+4	+8
DEX	20	+5	+9	WIS	16	+3	+7
CON	18	+4	+8	CHA	18	+4	+8

Skills Acrobatics +9, Insight +7, Investigation +8, Perception +11, Performance +12, Persuasion +8

Senses Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 21

Languages Common, Elvish plus 3 others

CR 9 (XP 5,000; PB +4)

TRAITS

Master of the Procession. Vesper and allied creatures within 30 feet of her cannot be surprised while she is conscious. When Initiative is rolled, Vesper may exchange the Initiative result of any two willing allied creatures she can see.

Read the Crowd. Vesper has Advantage on Wisdom (Insight) and Wisdom (Perception) checks involving groups of creatures. She knows whether a visible crowd is calm, frightened, hostile, or about to become violent.

Every Place Marked. Hostile creatures treat the ground within 20 feet of Vesper as Difficult Terrain. A creature can ignore this effect until the start of its next turn by succeeding on a DC 16 Wisdom saving throw at the beginning of its turn.

Fey Ancestry. Vesper has Advantage on saving throws against being Charmed, and magic cannot put her to sleep.

BEHAVIOR

- Becomes visibly irritated by unnecessary cruelty that distracts from the intended message.
- Quietly rehearses important ceremonies several times before allowing the condemned to appear.
- Treats prisoners respectfully until the instant their sentence is carried out.
- Adjusts every execution to reflect the crime, culture, and political purpose involved.
- Carries pieces of chalk used to mark positions for soldiers, witnesses, and bodies.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Vesper makes three Baton Blade or Hand Crossbow attacks.

Baton Blade. *Melee Attack Roll:* +9, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 9 (1d8 + 5) slashing damage plus 7 (2d6) psychic damage. Vesper may move the target 5 feet to an unoccupied space if it is Large or smaller.

Hand Crossbow. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +9, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d6 + 5) piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) poison damage.

Take Your Positions (Recharge 5–6). Vesper chooses up to four creatures she can see within 60 feet. Each unwilling target must succeed on a DC 16 Wisdom saving throw or be moved up to 20 feet to an unoccupied space Vesper can see. This movement does not provoke opportunity attacks. A creature moved adjacent to a Black Bell ally is Restrained until the beginning of Vesper's next turn.

Control the Square (1/Day). Vesper strikes her baton against the ground and commands silence. Each hostile creature of her choice within 60 feet that can hear her must make a DC 16 Charisma saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 27 (6d8) psychic damage and is Silenced until the end of Vesper's next turn. While Silenced in this way, it cannot speak, cast spells with verbal components, or activate items requiring a command word. On a successful save, the creature takes half as much damage and suffers no other effect.

BONUS ACTIONS

Mark the Stage. Vesper marks one 10-foot-square area of ground she can see within 60 feet. The area remains marked until the start of her next turn. Allied creatures have Advantage on attack rolls against enemies within the marked area.

Measured Redirection. Vesper moves up to half her Speed without provoking opportunity attacks. She may move through the spaces of hostile creatures during this movement, though she cannot end her movement there."

HOW SHE TALKS

Vesper speaks like a stage director giving instructions during a final rehearsal. Her words are concise, exact, and focused on position, timing, visibility, and effect. She rarely discusses whether a sentence is deserved, only whether its meaning will be understood.

Example Quote:

"Do not mistake spectacle for excess. A death witnessed poorly is only a corpse. A death witnessed properly can govern a city for twenty years."

INQUISITOR MAELIN VOSS

Lawful Evil, Female, Tiefling, 39, Keeper of the Unbroken Name

Maelin Voss was born in a city where identity could be purchased as easily as food. Criminals bribed clerks to alter birth records, nobles maintained false heirs, fugitives changed faces through magic, and wealthy offenders hired desperate strangers to serve their sentences. Maelin's mother worked as a courthouse scribe and was executed after being accused of falsifying the identity of a condemned smuggler.

Years later, Maelin discovered that her mother had been innocent. The smuggler had escaped by replacing himself with a magically altered prisoner, while the officials responsible destroyed the evidence and blamed the lowest-ranking clerk involved.

Maelin devoted herself to the study of names, bloodlines, physical marks, legal records, divination, and transformation magic. She became an investigator for the city courts, developing methods for identifying shapeshifters, disguised fugitives, altered memories, and magically fabricated documents.

Her skill made her useful, but not popular. Maelin exposed noble impostors, false witnesses, corrupt magistrates, and several respected officials whose identities had been built upon stolen records. When she proved that the city's ruling chancellor had secretly replaced his dead son with a doppelganger, the government attempted to have her silenced.

The Black Bell Company intervened before her arrest. It had been searching for the same false heir under an unresolved warrant.

Maelin joined the Company as an identity examiner and quickly became indispensable. She now investigates every disputed prisoner of political importance, tracing fugitives through family histories, scars, old debts, magical residue, habits, and the testimony of those who knew them before they learned to lie.

Her title, Keeper of the Unbroken Name, reflects her belief that identity cannot truly be erased. A face may change, a body may be transformed, and every written record may be burned, but a person leaves patterns behind.

Maelin rarely participates in the ceremony of execution. Her work ends when she places one hand upon the condemned, speaks their complete name, and declares before witnesses that the sentence has found its proper owner.



INQUISITOR MAELIN VOSS

Medium Humanoid (Tiefling), Lawful Evil

AC 17

HP 153 (18d8 + 72)

Speed 30 ft.

Initiative +4 (14)

		Mod	Save			Mod	Save
STR	10	+0	+4	INT	20	+5	+9
DEX	18	+4	+8	WIS	18	+4	+8
CON	18	+4	+8	CHA	16	+3	+7

Skills Arcana +9, History +9, Insight +12, Investigation +13, Perception +8, Religion +9

Damage Resistances Fire, Psychic

Senses Darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 18

Languages Common, Infernal plus 4 others

CR 10 (XP 5,900; PB +4)

TRAITS

Keeper of the Unbroken Name. Maelin automatically knows when a creature she can see within 30 feet is using a false name, magical disguise, transformed body, illusory appearance, or stolen identity. She does not automatically learn the creature's true identity.

No Substitute Accepted. Maelin has Advantage on attack rolls and ability checks against creatures that are shapechanged, disguised, possessing another body, or using illusion magic to conceal their appearance. Such creatures have Disadvantage on saving throws against Maelin's abilities.

Infernal Legacy. Maelin's spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 17, +9 to hit with spell attacks). She can innately cast the following spells, requiring no material components:

At will: *detect magic*, *mage hand*, *minor illusion*
3/day each: *detect thoughts*, *hold person*, *see invisibility*
1/day each: *locate creature*, *screying*, *true seeing*

Perfect Recollection. Maelin remembers every face, voice, signature, seal, and written passage she has examined for at least 1 minute. She has Advantage on Intelligence checks relating to creatures or documents she has previously studied.

BEHAVIOR

- Uses a person's full legal name whenever she knows it.
- Keeps fragments of handwriting, hair, wax seals, and blood from unresolved cases.
- Distrusts sudden memory loss and convenient claims of mistaken identity.
- Speaks politely to shapeshifters but never looks away from them.
- Corrects inaccurate records immediately, even during emergencies.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Maelin makes three attacks with her Examiner's Staff or Seal Needle.

Examiner's Staff. *Melee Attack Roll:* +8, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage plus 13 (3d8) psychic damage. The target cannot benefit from invisibility until the start of Maelin's next turn.

Seal Needle. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +8, range 30/90 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage plus 10 (3d6) necrotic damage. The target is magically marked until the end of Maelin's next turn and cannot change shape, teleport, or alter its appearance while marked.

Speak the True Name (Recharge 5–6). Maelin names one creature she can see within 60 feet. The target must make a DC 17 Charisma saving throw. On a failed save, all magical disguises, transformations, illusions, and possessions affecting the target are suppressed for 1 minute. The target also takes 31 (7d8) psychic damage and is Restrained until the end of its next turn. On a successful save, it takes half as much damage and its appearance is revealed until the start of Maelin's next turn.

Testimony of the Blood (1/Day). Maelin chooses one creature within 30 feet that has blood or possesses a physical body. The target must make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, Maelin learns its true name, creature type, original form, closest living blood relative, and whether it has knowingly assumed another person's identity. For the next 24 hours, Maelin always knows the direction and distance to that creature while it remains on the same plane.

BONUS ACTIONS

Mark the Fugitive. Maelin designates one creature she can see within 60 feet as her Fugitive. Until she marks a different creature, Maelin ignores Half Cover and Three-Quarters Cover when attacking the Fugitive, and the Fugitive cannot hide from her while within 120 feet.

Expose Contradiction. Maelin chooses one creature within 60 feet that she has heard speak during the current encounter. The creature must succeed on a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw or have Disadvantage on its next attack roll, ability check, or saving throw before the end of its next turn.

HOW SHE TALKS

Maelin speaks in a quiet, investigative manner, asking small and seemingly harmless questions before revealing that she already knows the answer. She rarely accuses someone directly until she has assembled enough evidence to make denial appear absurd.

Example Quote:

"Your face is convincing, your papers are flawless, and your memories are beautifully rehearsed. Unfortunately, you still favour the left leg you broke when you were nine."

WARDEN-CAPTAIN BRANNIK SORN

Lawful Evil, Male, Half-Orc, 51, Keeper of the Last Road

Brannik Sorn was born inside Drail's Gate, a quarry-prison where condemned labourers cut black stone for the walls of the capital. His mother maintained the prison wagons, while his father served among the chain guards who moved prisoners between cells, courts, and execution grounds. Brannik learned early that a sentence meant nothing if the condemned vanished before it could be carried out.

He entered service as a military gaoler and gained a reputation for returning prisoners alive regardless of distance, weather, bribery, or rescue attempts. He disliked torture and careless brutality, not from compassion, but because an injured prisoner was harder to transport, a dead prisoner could not confess, and an unauthorized killing weakened the authority of the court.

During the Ash Market Rebellion, Brannik was ordered to hold a captured rebel prince until a public execution could be arranged. The prince killed himself the night before the ceremony, leaving behind a final letter that transformed him into a martyr. Riots followed, the prison was burned, and the governor blamed Brannik for allowing the condemned to choose the manner and meaning of his own death.

Brannik accepted the accusation. He concluded that custody did not merely require preventing escape; it required denying the prisoner every unauthorized ending, including suicide, assassination, substitution, magical disappearance, or death during rescue.

The Black Bell Company recruited him after he transported the sorcerer-prince Olvar Dane across three hostile provinces. The prisoner's supporters poisoned the guards, collapsed bridges, summoned spirits into the wagon, and attempted to replace him with a magically altered corpse. Brannik delivered Olvar alive, conscious, correctly identified, and only six minutes behind the appointed procession.

He rose to command the Company's prison wagons, chain guards, route scouts, and anti-magic restraint teams. Before every major sentence, Brannik inspects the condemned, tests every lock, assigns overlapping watches, plans false routes, and prepares measures against rescue, possession, transformation, and self-harm. Once the procession begins, he remains within arm's reach of the prisoner until authority is formally transferred to the executioner.

Brannik treats the condemned with cold, impersonal care. He ensures that they are fed, washed, medically stable, and protected from unauthorized violence. This courtesy ends the instant the warrant permits their death.

His title, Keeper of the Last Road, reflects the Company's belief that every condemned person must complete the final journey chosen for them. Brannik

does not decide who deserves death, design the spectacle, or verify identity. His duty is simpler: the proper prisoner arrives at the proper place, alive enough to hear the sentence.



WARDEN-CAPTAIN BRANNIK SORN

Medium Humanoid (Half-Orc), Lawful Evil

AC 19

Initiative +2 (12)

HP 168 (20d8 + 80)

Speed 30 ft.

		Mod	Save			Mod	Save
STR	20	+5	+9	INT	14	+2	+6
DEX	14	+2	+6	WIS	18	+4	+8
CON	18	+4	+8	CHA	16	+3	+7

Skills Athletics +13, Insight +8, Intimidation +7, Perception +8, Survival +8

Condition Immunities Frightened

Senses Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 18

Languages Common, Orc plus 2 others

CR 10 (XP 5,900; PB +4)

TRAITS

Keeper of the Last Road. At the start of combat, Brannik designates one creature he can see within 60 feet as his Prisoner. Brannik always knows the direction of his Prisoner while it is within 1 mile of him and on the same plane. The Prisoner cannot benefit from the Disengage action while within Brannik's reach.

Iron Custody. Brannik has Advantage on ability checks made to grapple or restrain a creature. A creature grappled by Brannik is also Restrained and cannot teleport, change shape, become invisible, or move through creatures or objects.

Controlled Force. When Brannik reduces a creature to 0 Hit Points with a weapon attack, he may instead reduce it to 1 Hit Point and cause it to become Unconscious for 1 hour. The creature awakens if it takes damage or if another creature uses an action to wake it.

BEHAVIOR

- Personally tests every chain, lock, wagon door, and anti-magic seal before departure.
- Prevents guards, crowds, and employers from harming prisoners without written authorization.
- Sleeps inside the prison wagon during dangerous journeys.
- Counts prisoners, guards, keys, and restraints aloud at every transfer point.
- Treats escape, suicide, and rescue as failures of custody rather than acts of courage.

Convoy Discipline. Brannik and allied creatures within 30 feet of him have Advantage on saving throws against being moved or knocked Prone. Allied creatures in this area may move at full Speed while dragging a grappled creature.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Brannik makes three attacks with the Warden's Chain or Shackle Bolt.

Warden's Chain. *Melee Attack Roll:* +9, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 11 (1d12 + 5) slashing damage plus 7 (2d6) psychic damage. Brannik may pull a Large or smaller target up to 10 feet toward himself. If the target is his Prisoner, he may grapple it instead.

Shackle Bolt. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +8, range 60/180 ft. *Hit:* 9 (1d10 + 4) piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) force damage. The target's Speed is reduced by 10 feet, and it cannot take Reactions until the start of Brannik's next turn.

Lock the Sentence (Recharge 5–6). Brannik throws a pair of rune-inscribed manacles at one creature he can see within 60 feet. The target must make a DC 17 Strength saving throw. On a failed save, it takes 27 (6d8) force damage and is Restrained for 1 minute. While Restrained in this way, the creature cannot teleport, become incorporeal, change shape, or alter its appearance. The creature repeats the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on a success. On a successful initial save, the creature takes half as much damage and is not Restrained.

Close the Road (1/Day). Brannik strikes his chain against the ground, creating spectral prison bars in a 30-foot Emanation originating from himself. Each hostile creature of his choice in the area must make a DC 17 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 31 (7d8) force damage, is pulled up to 15 feet toward Brannik, and has the Restrained condition until the end of its next turn. On a successful save, it takes half as much damage and is not pulled or Restrained.

HOW HE TALKS

Brannik speaks in short, practical statements resembling entries in a prison ledger. He refers to people as prisoners, witnesses, custodians, and authorized recipients according to their current role. He rarely threatens anyone emotionally; instead, he describes exactly which restraints, routes, and procedures will make resistance ineffective.

Example Quote:

"You may curse the court, refuse the meal, bite through your tongue, or pray for rescue. None of these actions alter the destination."

MEMBERSHIP

The Black Bell Company recruits people who can place procedure above anger, sympathy, fear, and personal ambition. Most candidates are experienced soldiers, gaolers, executioners, clerks, heralds, investigators, physicians, engineers, magistrates, or mages trained in restraint, detection, and crowd control. The Company has little interest in reckless killers. A recruit who enjoys punishment too openly is considered unreliable because private cruelty can interfere with the meaning and authority of a formal sentence.

Applicants must present a verified identity, disclose previous military and legal obligations, and submit to an examination of their debts, loyalties, criminal history, and family connections. Any unresolved warrant against the applicant must be settled before induction. The Company will not knowingly employ a fugitive while claiming to enforce the sentences of others.

Each candidate completes a supervised procession in which they must secure a route, control witnesses, protect a condemned prisoner from rescue and unauthorized harm, and preserve all records connected to the sentence. The trial is judged on discipline, accuracy, and restraint rather than the number of enemies killed.

Successful recruits receive a First Toll token and swear before the Company bell that they will recognize authenticated warrants, obey the established chain of command, protect prisoners until the appointed moment, and never alter a sentence for personal reasons.

Membership is denied to uncontrolled sadists, habitual deserters, political fanatics, people who refuse written authority, and anyone who cannot distinguish an official execution from private murder. Once accepted, a member is considered part of the Procession and remains subject to Company judgment even between contracts.

RENOWN

The Black Bell Company is renowned for completing politically dangerous executions that ordinary soldiers, courts, and rulers cannot safely perform. Its processions have crossed hostile borders, entered rebellious cities, resisted rescue attempts, and delivered condemned fugitives who were believed untouchable.

Its reputation was secured during the Execution of the Twelve Towers, when twelve rebellious lords were executed simultaneously in twelve different cities. The coordination ended the rebellion without another major battle and established the Company as a symbol of unavoidable judgment.

Today, the appearance of its ash-grey banners and the sound of its iron bell can cause fugitives to surrender, conspirators to abandon their allies, and rebellions to

collapse before the Company carries out a single sentence.

TRINKET

Each new member of the Black Bell Company receives a palm-sized iron token known as a First Toll. It resembles a small black bell, but it contains no clapper and cannot produce an ordinary sound. The member's name, rank, date of induction, and commanding officer are engraved inside its hollow body in lettering too small to read without a magnifying lens.

The token serves as proof that the bearer is under Company discipline and may lawfully carry its weapons, restraints, seals, and uniform. Officers also use it to confirm chains of command during divided operations, prison transfers, and politically disputed contracts.

When pressed against an authentic Black Bell warrant, the First Toll grows cold and produces a faint vibration that only its bearer can feel. Forged warrants, altered seals, and unauthorized copies cause no response. This test is useful but not infallible, as the token confirms that a document entered the Company archives rather than proving that the authority behind it was just.

Once per Long Rest, the bearer may strike the token against a weapon, shield, or stone surface. Although no audible sound is produced, the bearer hears a single toll within their mind and gains Advantage on one saving throw against being Charmed or Frightened made within the next minute.



MEMBER SERVICES

WARRANT AND LEGAL PROTECTION

Members acting under an authenticated Company warrant receive legal representation, documented authority, and access to negotiators who deal with local courts, rulers, military commanders, and religious officials. The Company protects members from being abandoned by employers who later deny ordering a controversial sentence.

EQUIPMENT AND UNIFORM MAINTENANCE

The Company supplies approved armour, ash-grey uniforms, warrant cases, crowd-control weapons, manacles, anti-magic restraints, execution tools, and ceremonial insignia appropriate to a member's role. Damaged equipment is repaired or replaced, while every bell, seal, chain, and weapon is inspected before an important procession.

MEDICAL AND CUSTODIAL RECOVERY

Members wounded during arrests, prison transfers, riots, rescue attempts, or executions receive disciplined battlefield treatment and guarded recovery. The Company also retrieves captured members whenever possible, since prisoners may possess active warrants, confidential records, or knowledge that cannot be allowed to pass into hostile hands.

TRAINING AND CERTIFICATION

Members may train in crowd control, prisoner transport, seal recognition, genealogy, legal procedure, languages, anti-illusion methods, execution-site defense, ceremonial speaking, and the use of specialized restraints. Formal certifications allow experienced members to advance into roles such as warrant examiner, procession marshal, chain captain, herald, or sanctioned executioner.

PAY, PENSIONS, AND HOUSEHOLD SUPPORT

Contract earnings are distributed according to rank, risk, and responsibility rather than kills. Long-serving members receive pensions, burial arrangements, and support for recognized dependents. If a member dies while completing a valid sentence, the Company records the death in its archives and ensures that unpaid compensation is collected from the employer.

RETALIATORY PROTECTION

The Black Bell Company treats attacks against its members, their households, or its official records as attempts to obstruct lawful process. Proven offenders may be investigated, publicly named, financially ruined, arrested under a new commission, or pursued through future contracts. Members therefore gain the protection of an organization known for remembering interference long after ordinary mercenary companies would have moved on.

FEAT: BLACK BELL DISCIPLINE

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Membership in the Black Bell Company)

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Wisdom or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Unshaken Procedure. You have Advantage on saving throws you make to avoid or end the Frightened condition.

Deny Escape. When a creature you can see within 30 feet willingly moves at least 5 feet away from you or from a creature you are guarding, you can take a Reaction and force it to make a Wisdom saving throw. The DC equals 8 plus your Proficiency Bonus plus the modifier of the ability increased by this feat. On a failed save, the creature's Speed becomes 0 for the rest of the current turn.

You can use Deny Escape a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus and regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

IMPORTANT NPCs

#	NAME & TITLE	DESCRIPTION
1	High Executioner Garran Vell	A disciplined human headsman who performs the Company's most politically sensitive sentences. He refuses unnecessary pain because a failed execution weakens the authority of the warrant.
2	Master Herald Ilyra Quill	An aasimar officer whose magically strengthened voice can carry charges across an entire city square. She memorizes every warrant but refuses to change even a single word.
3	Archivist-Prime Nera Vale	An elderly dwarf who controls access to unresolved warrants, bloodline records, confessions, and countermand orders. She knows which rulers built their authority upon forgotten executions.
4	Bellwright Hadrik Mourn	A gnome engineer responsible for maintaining the Company's great iron bells, portable belfries, and sound-based magical equipment. He can identify tampering from a bell's first vibration.
5	Surgeon-Lector Salven Marr	An elven physician who keeps condemned prisoners alive, conscious, and medically fit until the appointed hour. He also records the exact cause and time of every death.
6	Countermand Knight Tamsin Grey	A heavily armored courier trusted to carry pardons, suspensions, and amended sentences through riots and battlefields. She is one of the few officers authorized to halt an active procession.

